Data Retention Policy

This policy defines how long each class of data is kept, who is permitted to access it, and how deletion is verified. It applies to every production system and to any copy of production data held elsewhere, including analytics warehouses and backups.

Scope

The policy covers customer records, operational telemetry, application logs, audit trails and backups. It does not cover source code, build artefacts or internal documentation, which are governed separately by the engineering handbook.

Where a contractual obligation specifies a retention period different from this policy, the contract takes precedence. Such cases must be recorded in the retention register so that the exception is visible during audit rather than discovered during one.

Retention Periods

Customer records are retained for the life of the account plus seven years, driven by financial reporting obligations rather than by any product requirement.

Application logs are retained for thirty days in hot storage and a further eleven months in cold storage. Cold storage is not queryable directly; retrieving from it takes up to twelve hours and requires an approved access request.

Operational telemetry, meaning metrics and traces rather than logs, is retained for thirteen months. The extra month past a year exists so that year-over-year comparisons remain possible at the end of a reporting period.

Audit trails are retained for seven years and are immutable. No process, including this one, may shorten audit trail retention.

Deletion and Verification

Deletion requests are processed within thirty days. The request is fanned out to every system holding a copy, and each system reports completion independently. A request is only closed once every system has reported.

Backups are the common source of incomplete deletion. Because backups are immutable snapshots, a record cannot be surgically removed from an existing backup. Instead the record is suppressed on restore, and the backup ages out naturally under the thirty-five day backup retention window.

Access Control

Access to customer records in production requires an approved access request tied to a named ticket. Approvals expire after eight hours. Standing access to production customer data is not granted to any individual role.

Every access is logged to the audit trail with the requester, the ticket, the records touched and the justification given. Audit trail entries are reviewed monthly by the compliance function.